

Social + virality

Week 7 Lecture 1 · B2C to \$10k MRR

Autumn 2026 · Growth Manual for Technical Founders

What we'll cover

- Build-in-public mechanics: the Marc Lou and Tony Dinh playbooks
- TikTok and the demo-shaped product opportunity
- Share cards: viral assets baked into the product
- K-factor: the one number that separates viral loops from growth loops
- Viral loops vs growth loops vs referral loops

Build-in-public

Build-in-public is distribution, not diary

- Shipping publicly creates an audience before the product is finished
- Every post is a micro-launch: feedback, social proof, and indexable content
- Marc Lou: free tool marketing + daily Twitter posts drove ShipFast from \$0 to \$45k/month
- Tony Dinh: "Twitter lets me have a direct line to my users before, during, and after launch. That's worth more than any ad budget." (Indie Hackers Podcast #260)
- The channel is not passive: every post must create a reason to click

The Marc Lou formula

Four rules that made free-tool marketing work for ShipFast (Marc Lou, 2024):

1. **Free:** enables sharing without friction
2. **Minimal scope:** one job, no onboarding
3. **No signup:** zero friction for the referral visitor
4. **Descriptive name:** doubles as SEO, not just branding

Marc Lou achieved 30% conversion from free tool to paid product by keeping the handoff natural (Marc Lou, Lenny's Newsletter 2024)

Build-in-public on X: what actually works

- Post the output, not the process: "I shipped X and here's what happened" outperforms "today I worked on..."
- Transparency creates shareability: revenue numbers, failure rates, conversion screenshots
- Pieter Levels' Nomad List grew to \$20-40k/month with no paid spend, driven by a single spreadsheet tweet that hit #1 on Product Hunt and Hacker News (levels.io, 2024)
- Arvid Kahl: "Twitter is a sandbox. Everyone can talk to everyone else, and this creates enormous potential for your ideas to reach the right people." (Find Your Following, 2022)

K-factor and viral loops

The K-factor formula

Andrew Chen's definition (Braindump on Viral Loops, 2025):

$$K = (\text{invites or shares sent per existing user}) \times (\text{conversion rate on those invites})$$

- $K > 1.0$: exponential growth (rare, don't count on it)
- $K = 0.9$: 10x amplification of paid/organic input
- $K = 0.75$: 4x amplification
- $K = 0.5$: 2x amplification
- Most early products: K between 0.05 and 0.3

What kills K-factor

Chen's three failure modes (Braindump on Viral Loops, 2025):

1. **Email-era invite mechanics:** spam filters ended the 2005-2010 golden age
2. **Single-session conversion pressure:** modern users don't sign up from one cold tap
3. **No retention foundation:** "Modern virality depends on retention-driven loops across multiple sessions rather than single-session conversions"

The fix: design sharing into the retained user's natural workflow

Viral loop vs growth loop

Viral loop

Growth loop

- User triggers sharing
 - Share brings in a new user
 - New user starts the loop again
 - Measured by K-factor
 - Input: a retained user's action
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- Output of one user cohort becomes input for the next
 - May or may not involve sharing
 - Also includes content loops, paid loops, sales loops
 - Defined by Balfour & Winters (Reforge)

Growth loops compound; funnels don't

Balfour & Winters (Reforge, 2019) on why loops beat funnels:

- A funnel measures one cohort. A loop asks: how does cohort 1 generate cohort 2?
- Four acquisition loop types: viral, content, sales, paid
- Each loop type has a different flywheel speed and capital requirement
- Elena Verna: "Growth tactics without a product loop are decorations, not engines." (Lenny's Podcast, 2025)

The share-card tactic

What an effective share-card mechanic looks like:

- The card is generated *by the product* at a moment of user achievement
- The sharer looks good to their audience (not: "please use my app")
- The card contains the product name and a URL passively
- Share rate follows trigger quality: better trigger = more shares

Design principle: the user shares because they want to, not because you asked

Duolingo's share-result loop

The Duolingo streak share as a worked example:

1. User completes a streak milestone (the retention event)
2. Product surfaces a designed share card tied to that achievement
3. User shares because it signals discipline and progress to their network
4. New viewer sees the card and thinks "I want that streak too"
5. Click converts at a higher rate than cold ads because the trust transfer is social

The retention event and the viral asset are the same moment

TikTok and the demo

TikTok is an acquisition channel for demo-shaped products

- The demo is the content: show the product working, not an ad
- "I just shipped it. I didn't ask for permission. I shipped it and saw if people wanted it." (Pieter Levels, Lex Fridman Podcast #440, 2024)
- Products with a visual output (image generators, design tools, analytics dashboards) have natural TikTok loops
- The comment section is your user-research queue
- Low CPM for cold traffic; high drop-off if the product's first-use experience is poor

Take-aways

1. Build-in-public works because each post is a micro-launch, not a diary entry.
2. K-factor measures how many new users each existing user generates. Most early products have K between 0.05 and 0.3.
3. Viral loops and growth loops are not the same: a viral loop is one subtype of growth loop.
4. Modern virality lives in retained users' natural actions, not one-time invite blasts.
5. The share-card trigger must make the sharer look good; otherwise shares are low even if the card design is excellent.

Modern virality depends on retention-driven loops across multiple sessions rather than single-session conversions.

- Andrew Chen, *Braindump on Viral Loops* (2025)

What's next

- **Section this week:** Design and ship your own viral asset; wire share-click telemetry
- **Reading:** Week 7 reading at </c/b2c-10k-mrr-26au/readings/wk07>
- **Lecture 2:** Paid acquisition basics: CAC ceiling, conversion API, creative as leverage
- **Friday:** Pull your share_clicked events; compute your first real K-factor estimate